casualties. 13 Kumaon's Charlie Company under the command of Major Shaitan Singh had moved in and replaced 1/8 GR at Rezang-la on 6 November. Point 18300 dominated the pass in the north and another peak, in excess of 18,000 feet, towered over it to the east. To the south and to the west there was a drop of around 1,900 feet. The pass itself was situated at an average height of 16,000 feet and its northern shoulder was higher than the southern side.

When the original defences had been laid out by 7 J&K Militia, it had been presumed that the Chinese could not approach Rezang-la either from the northwest or the east because of the high features and the fact that any movement in the PT 18300 area would be detected by Indian patrols. However, originating from the northeast of the pass was a stream that flowed to the north, where it joined another small stream that then flowed into the Spanggur Tso. This depression was known as Valley West and as per the Indian appreciation, considered to be the most likely approach if and when Rezang-la was to be attacked. The approach from the south was dominated by Tsaka-la while to the west lay the Chushul Valley.

Accordingly No. 8 Platoon, commanded by Naib Subedar Hari Ram, occupied the area of the main pass, No. 7 Platoon, under Naib Subedar Surja Singh, was deployed on a high spur jutting out on the left bank of Valley West and No. 9 Platoon, commanded by Naib Subedar Ram Chand, was positioned in between. All three localities individually were sited to dominate Valley West, but unfortunately, none of them were mutually supporting. Shaitan Singh's own command post was situated to the west of No. 8 Platoon, while the 3-inch mortar section was situated another 150 yards beyond Company HQ. All three platoons laid their fixed line of fire along Valley West, as did the mortar detachment.

On the morning of 17 November, Rezang-la reported some activity towards the north and a message was relayed through Tsaka-la to the 13 Kumaon Battalion HQ asking for reinforcements. Towards the evening, another column comprising over a 100 yaks, their handlers and some troops were seen south of PT 18300. Not expecting a Chinese assault from that direction, Shaitan Singh came to the conclusion it was an Indian column that was approaching in response to his call for support earlier that morning.

However, what the Kumaonis had seen was in fact the first of four Chinese columns that had been dispatched against Rezang-la. Accompanied by an artillery forward observer, it began to climb the northern slope of PT